Topic 6 — Protected Areas & Conservation

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Wildlife Sanctuary | National Park | Biosphere Reserve (जैवमंडल आरक्षित क्षेत्र) | Conservation Reserve (संरक्षण आरक्षित क्षेत्र) | Community Reserve (सामुदायिक आरक्षित क्षेत्र) | Tiger Reserve | Elephant Reserve (हाथी अभयारण्य) | Marine Protected Areas | Ramsar (रामसर) Sites | UNESCO World Heritage (विश्व धरोहर) Sites | Eco-Sensitive Zones

Sources baked in: WPA 1972 (amended 2002, 2006), EPA 1986, Ramsar Convention, UNESCO MAB/WH, NTCA, MoEFCC, UPPCS PYQs 2018–2025 **Weight:** ★★★ High — PA comparison, location matching, UP Ramsar traps **Last verified:** August 2026

Current Affairs (this topic)

- Track new Ramsar notifications and tiger-reserve counts against the Must-Score totals.
- Keep UP Ramsar **12** and India **~100** as the teaching baseline unless a stem cites (साइट्स) a later official total.

6.1 Wildlife Sanctuary

Identity: WPA Sec 18 | State declares | Human use with CWLW permission

- A **Wildlife Sanctuary (WLS)** (वन्यजीव अभयारण्य) is a protected area where wildlife is conserved in natural habitat (वास स्थान).
- The **State Government** declares a sanctuary under **WPA Section 18**.
- Hunting, poaching, and capturing wildlife are prohibited inside a sanctuary.
- Other activities such as grazing or collection of minor forest produce may continue if the **Chief Wildlife Warden (CWLW)** permits them.
- India has about **573 Wildlife Sanctuaries**.
- Sanctuaries are **in-situ** (स्थान पर) conservation tools that protect whole habitats, not just one species.
- A sanctuary can later be upgraded to a **National Park** with stricter rules.

Feature	Wildlife Sanctuary	National Park
WPA section	Sec 18–27	Sec 35
Human activity	Allowed with CWLW permission	Largely prohibited
Grazing / forestry	May be permitted	Prohibited
Biomass collection	Limited use may be allowed	**Not** allowed as in sanctuary

Feature	Wildlife Sanctuary	National Park
Boundary change	State process	Needs **State Legislature** resolution
Strictness	Moderate (नरम दल)	**Highest** among WPA terrestrial PAs

> **Logic:** Trap — "no human activity is allowed in any wildlife sanctuary" is **false**. NP boundary change = **State Legislature**, not Parliament.

6.2 National Park

Identity: WPA Sec 35 | Strictest terrestrial PA | First = Corbett 1936

- A **National Park (NP)** (राष्ट्रीय उद्यान) is the **strictest** category of terrestrial protected area under WPA.
- The **State Government** notifies a national park under **WPA Section 35**.
- Grazing, hunting, forestry, and private exploitation are **prohibited** inside a national park.
- Altering a national park boundary requires a resolution of the **Legislature of the State** (WPA Sec 35) — **not Parliament**.
- Local people are **not** allowed to collect and use biomass in a National Park the way limited biotic interference may be permitted in a sanctuary.
- India's first national park was **Hailey National Park**, now **Corbett National Park (1936)** in Uttarakhand (उत्तराखंड).
- Uttar Pradesh's major national park is **Dudhwa National Park** (दुधवा राष्ट्रीय उद्यान) in the Terai (rhino rehabilitation from **1984**).

> **Logic:** tests NP location matching. Keoladeo (केवलादेव) is in **Rajasthan** (थार). Dachigam is in **Jammu & Kashmir**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q90

Match List-I with List-II:

List-I: A. Dachigam B. Keoladeo C. Kanha (कान्हा) D. Periyar (पेरियार) List-II: 1. Madhya Pradesh 2. Rajasthan 3. Kerala 4. Jammu and Kashmir

A. 4 2 1 3

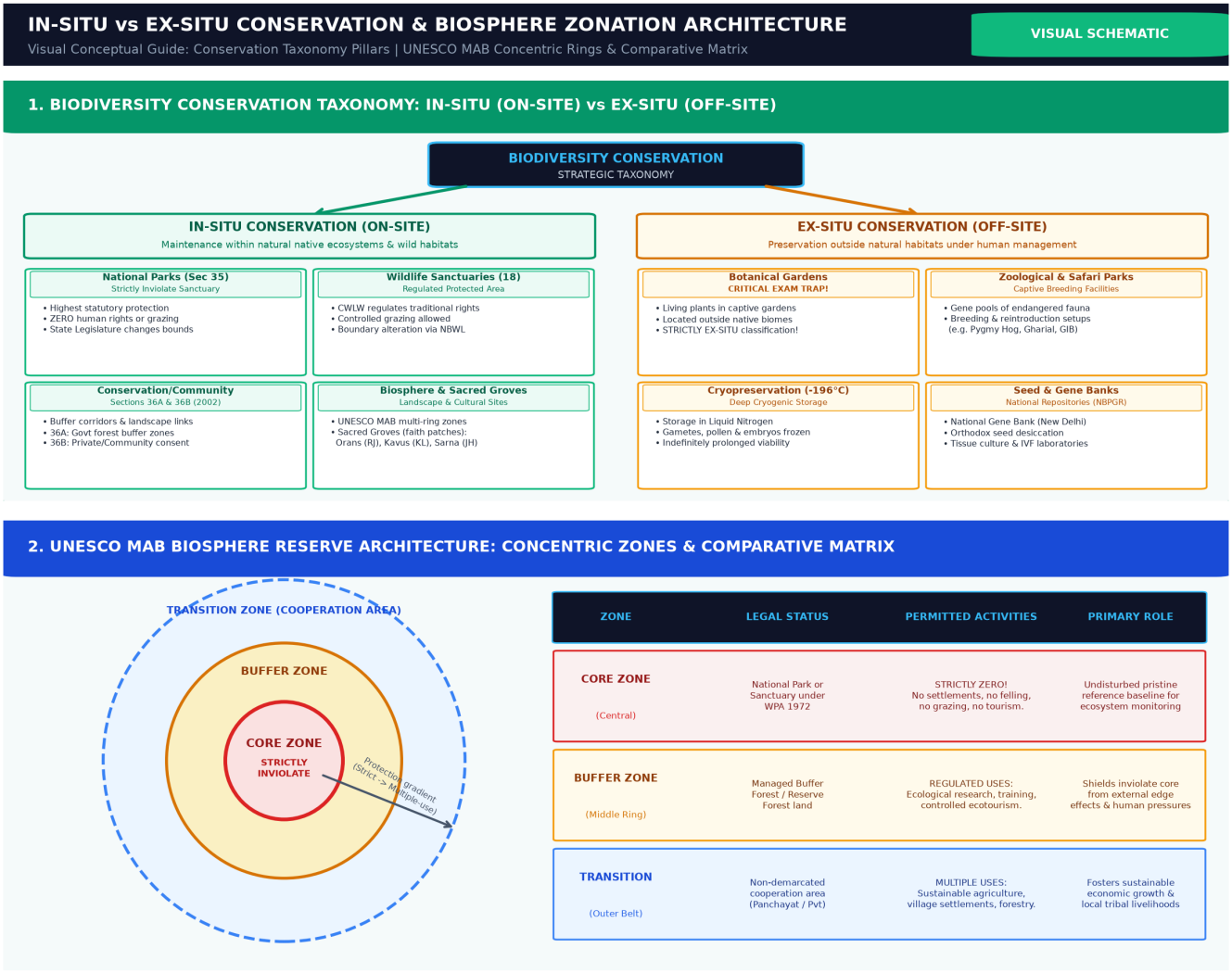
B. 2 4 3 1

C. 4 2 3 1

D. 4 2 1 3

Show answer

Ans: D — Dachigam=J&K; Keoladeo=Rajasthan; Kanha=MP; Periyar=Kerala.

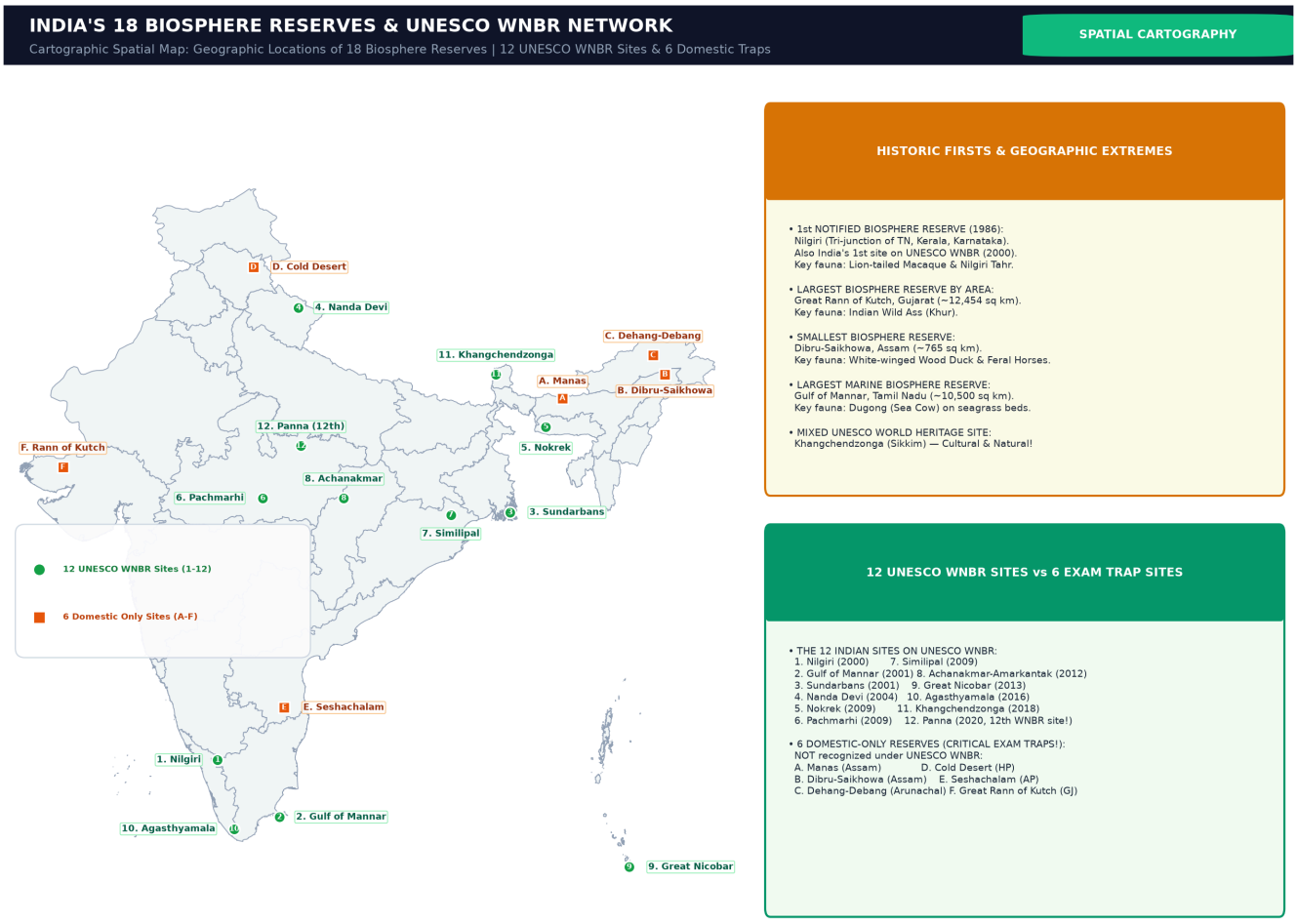


6.3 Biosphere Reserve

Identity: UNESCO MAB 1971 | Core–Buffer–Transition | 18 notified | No WPA basis

- A **Biosphere Reserve (BR)** (जैवमंडल आरक्षित क्षेत्र) is a large landscape for conservation, research, and sustainable community use under UNESCO's **Man and the Biosphere (MAB) Programme**.
- India notified its first BR, **Nilgiri** (नीलगिरि), in **1986**.
- India has **18 notified Biosphere Reserves**. **13** are in UNESCO's World Network of Biosphere Reserves.
- Every BR has three zones. The **core** zone bans exploitative human activity (strict protection / genetic diversity (आनुवंशिक विविधता)). The **buffer** allows limited research, education, regulated eco-tourism and grazing. The **transition** zone permits settlements, cultivation, and regulated sustainable livelihoods.
- BRs conserve **in situ all forms of life** with support systems — they are **not** declared merely to conserve "a few specific species."
- BRs are **executive notifications** by MoEFCC (पर्यावरण, वन और जलवायु परिवर्तन मंत्रालय). They do **not** have a separate statutory category under WPA, though core areas often overlap with national parks or sanctuaries.

- **Nokrek** is in **Meghalaya** (Garo (गारो) Hills; Nokrek peak), not Manipur. **Simlipal** is in **Odisha** (ओडिशा). **Agasthyamalai** spans **Kerala and Tamil Nadu (तमिलनाडु)** (Neyyar, Peppara, Shendurney WLS + Kalakad–Mundanthurai TR).
- The **largest** national BR by area is **Great Rann of Kutch** (Gujarat). Among UNESCO-certified Indian BRs by area, **Gulf of Mannar** is often cited as the largest. The **smallest** is **Nokrek** (Meghalaya).
- Area order among common options: **Gulf of Mannar > Sundarbans (सुंदरबन) > Pachmarhi > Khangchendzonga**.



#	Biosphere Reserve	State(s)
1	Nilgiri	Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Kerala
2	Nanda Devi (नंदा देवी)	Uttarakhand
3	Nokrek	**Meghalaya**
4	Gulf of Mannar	Tamil Nadu
5	Sundarbans	West Bengal
6	Manas	Assam
7	Great Nicobar	Andaman & Nicobar
8	Simlipal	Odisha
9	Dibru-Saikhowa	Assam

#	Biosphere Reserve	State(s)
10	Dihang-Dibang	Arunachal Pradesh
11	Pachmarhi	Madhya Pradesh
12	Khangchendzonga	Sikkim
13	Agasthyamalai	Kerala, Tamil Nadu
14	Achanakmar-Amarkantak	MP, Chhattisgarh
15	Great Rann of Kutch	Gujarat
16	Cold Desert	Himachal (हिमाचल) Pradesh
17	Seshachalam Hills	Andhra Pradesh
18	Panna	Madhya Pradesh

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q144

Which of the following pairs is/are NOT correctly matched?

(Biosphere Reserve) — (State)

1. Nokrek — Manipur
2. Manas — Assam
3. Agasthyamalai — Kerala

A. Only 1

B. Only 2

C. Only 3

D. Only 1 and 3

Show answer

Ans: A — Nokrek = **Meghalaya**.

6.4 Conservation Reserve

Identity: WPA Sec 36A (2002) | Buffer forest near PA

- A **Conservation Reserve** protects forest areas that act as **buffers or corridors** next to national parks or sanctuaries.
- It was added by the **WPA Amendment, 2002** under **Section 36A**.
- The **State Government** declares it on **government-owned or community-owned forest land**.
- Human activity is more flexible than in a national park. Traditional uses may continue under regulation.
- **Asan (आसन) Conservation Reserve** in Uttarakhand is a known example and is also a Ramsar site.

> **Logic:** Conservation Reserve = **forest buffer**. Community Reserve = **private/community land**. Do not swap them.

6.5 Community Reserve

Identity: WPA Sec 36B (2002) | Voluntary community consent

- A **Community Reserve** is declared on **private or community land** when local people agree to conserve wildlife.
- It was added by the **WPA Amendment, 2002** under **Section 36B**.
- The **State Government** notifies it after receiving **voluntary community consent**.
- It is the most community-led WPA protected-area category.
- Community Reserves supplement strict PAs where full national park notification is socially difficult.

> **Logic:** Community Reserve requires **consent**. Conservation Reserve does **not** require private individual land.

6.6 Tiger Reserve

Identity: WPA Sec 38V (2006) | NTCA 2005 | Core + Buffer mandatory

- A **Tiger Reserve (TR)** is a protected area notified specifically for tiger conservation under **WPA Section 38V**.
- The **National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA)** was created in **2005** and given statutory status by the **2006 WPA amendment**.
- Every tiger reserve must have a **core** area kept inviolate for tigers and a **buffer** area for regulated human use.
- India's first tiger reserve was **Corbett (1973)** under **Project Tiger (प्रोजेक्ट टाइगर) (1973)** (प्रोजेक्ट टाइगर).
- India had **58 tiger reserves** after the notification of **Madhav Tiger Reserve** (2025).
- UP tiger reserves include **Dudhwa (1987)**, **Pilibhit (2014)**, and **Ranipur (2023)**.

> **Logic:** Tiger Reserves have **WPA statutory backing**. Elephant Reserves do **not**.

6.7 Elephant Reserve

Identity: Project Elephant 1992 | Executive notification | No WPA basis

- An **Elephant Reserve (ER)** is declared under **Project Elephant** (प्रोजेक्ट एलीफेंट), launched in **1992**.
- It is an **executive/administrative** category. It is **not** a separate statutory category under WPA.

- ERs aim to protect elephant corridors and reduce human–elephant conflict across **14 elephant-range states**.
- India has **33 Elephant Reserves**.
- UP has the **Uttar Pradesh Elephant Reserve (2009)** and the **Terai Elephant Reserve (2022)**.

> **Logic:** Trap — "Elephant Reserves are declared under WPA like Tiger Reserves" is **false**.

6.8 Marine Protected Areas

Identity: Marine NP/WLS under WPA | CRZ under EPA | UP has none

- **Marine Protected Areas (MPAs)** include **Marine National Parks** and **Marine Wildlife Sanctuaries** notified under WPA.
- India's first marine national park is **Gulf of Kutch Marine National Park, Gujarat (1980)**.
- **Gahirmatha Marine Sanctuary** in Odisha is famous for olive ridley turtle nesting.
- Coastal regulation also uses **CRZ** rules under the **EPA 1986**.
- **Uttar Pradesh has no marine protected area** because it is landlocked.

> **Logic:** Negative questions may use UP as the state with **zero** marine PAs.

6.9 Ramsar Sites

Identity: Ramsar Convention 1971 | India joined 1982 | Wise use of wetlands

- A **Ramsar site** is a wetland of **international importance** designated under the **Ramsar Convention (1971)** (रामसर कन्वेंशन).
- India became a contracting party in **February 1982**.
- **World Wetlands Day** (विश्व आर्द्रभूमि दिवस) is **2 February** (रामसर).
- India has about **100 Ramsar sites** (among the highest globally).
- Ramsar designation follows the **wise use** principle. Wetlands may support fishing, tourism, and local livelihoods if managed sustainably.
- Ramsar status does **not** change land ownership. WPA protections on the site continue.
- **Uttar Pradesh has 12 Ramsar sites**.
- **Rudrasagar Lake** is in **Tripura**, not UP.
- **Sultanpur National Park** is in **Haryana**, not UP.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q58

Which of the following Ramsar sites are NOT located in Uttar Pradesh?

1. Sarsai Nawar Jheel
2. Samaspur Bird Sanctuary

3. Rudrasagar Lake
4. Sultanpur National Park

A. 1 and 3

B. 3 and 4

C. 2 and 3

D. 1 and 2

Show answer

Ans: B — Rudrasagar = Tripura. Sultanpur = Haryana. Samaspur and Sarsai Nawar are in UP.

6.10 UNESCO World Heritage Sites (Natural)

Identity: WH Convention 1972 | Natural vs cultural | India natural WH sites

- **UNESCO World Heritage Sites** are places of outstanding universal value under the **World Heritage Convention (1972)**.
- **Natural** World Heritage Sites are recognised for exceptional natural beauty or biodiversity.
- India's major **natural** World Heritage Sites include **Kaziranga**, **Manas**, **Keoladeo**, **Sundarbans** (सुंदरबन), **Nanda Devi and Valley of Flowers (फूलों की घाटी)**, **Western Ghats**, **Great Himalayan National Park** (हिमाचल), and **Khangchendzonga**.
- **Keoladeo** is both a Ramsar wetland and a UNESCO natural World Heritage Site (प्राकृतिक विश्व धरोहर स्थल).
- **Uttar Pradesh has no natural UNESCO World Heritage Site**. Nanda Devi is in **Uttarakhand** (उत्तराखंड).

> **Logic:** Do not confuse **natural WH sites** with **cultural WH sites** such as Jaipur city.

6.11 Eco-Sensitive Zones (ESZ)

Identity: EPA 1986 | Buffer around PA | Restricts mining and polluting industry

- An **Eco-Sensitive Zone (ESZ)** is a regulated **buffer belt** around a national park, wildlife sanctuary, or other protected area.
- ESZs are notified under the **Environment (पर्यावरण) (Protection) Act, 1986**, not under WPA.
- The Supreme Court has guided ESZ notification to reduce mining, polluting industries, and major construction near protected areas.
- ESZ width is notified case by case. It is **not** a fixed 10 km rule for every protected area in all states.
- ESZs aim to reduce shock between strict protected cores and surrounding development.

> **Logic:** ESZ = **EPA 1986**. National Park = **WPA 1972**. Do not swap the two laws.
